relationship as we do.… We should treat the Chinese like ordinary humans. Perhaps then they would start to act that way."[141] A defensive Oksenberg denied that there had been a unilateral and "undignified" American push for a meeting, as Thornton alleged. He cattily added, "It is clear Tom feels cowed by Sinologists. I am not surprised. Indianists, reflecting India, are generally cowed."[142]

The Carter multination tour was eventually postponed to early January 1978. Ahead of that trip, Brzezinski, in background press briefings, outlined the reasons for India being on the itinerary. For one, it was a "terribly important historical experiment" as a developing democracy. The Desai government, moreover, believed in nonalignment that was "genuinely even-handed." The national security adviser denied that anti-Sovietism was a theme. Privately, however, Thornton's briefing for Carter had noted that Desai's desire to improve US relations to "avoid overdependence" on Moscow was even stronger than Gandhi's in her last two years.[143] Another reason for the trip was that, for Carter, Delhi had to be part of any solution to the nuclear problem. Finally, Brzezinski outlined, India was "critically important … in strategic terms given the centrality of India's location in relationship to the Soviet Union and China."[144]

The Carter administration failed to get India to agree to full-scope safeguards for its nuclear reactors—the administration's main objective for the trip—but American officials nonetheless saw the visit as a "solid success."[145] China featured in the two leaders' discussion. Ahead of the visit, US ambassador Goheen had noted that it was crucial to recognize "the extent to which China figures in the rationalizations of India's leaders" on nuclear policy and beyond. In Delhi, in meetings with the visiting delegation, Indian officials stressed the importance of including China in nonproliferation efforts. Carter told Desai that the US hoped to get China to join a comprehensive test ban. He noted that Sino-US normalization remained on the agenda although the process had stalled. Desai stated that the "Chinese [were] a difficult people" but they would come around. He was glad that Washington was trying to improve relations with China but hoped that it would not abandon Taiwan in the process—Carter assured him that it would not. Desai updated the president on Indian steps toward normalization—despite Soviet concerns—but added that China and India "cannot be close" until the boundary issue was settled.[146]